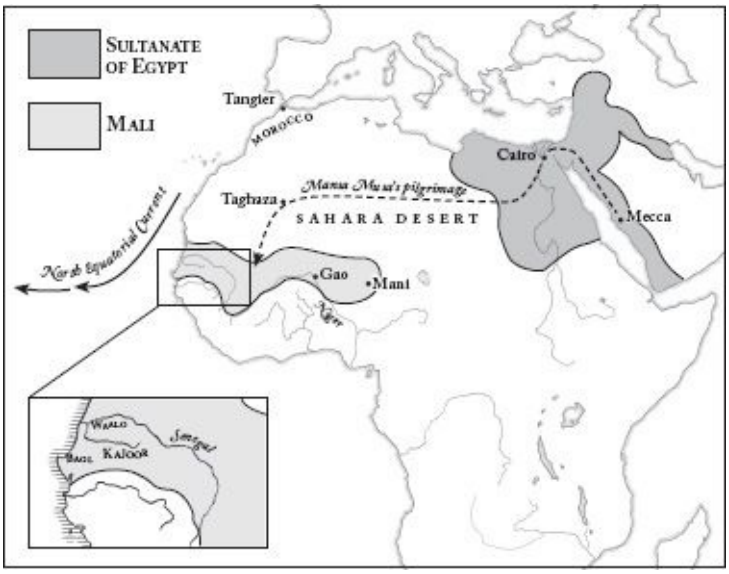


65.1 The Height of Mali

Either the king or his accountants lacked foresight, though; the Mali monarch spent most of his money on his initial passage through Cairo, and by the time he returned through the city after his pilgrimage to the Ka'aba, he was broke. He had to borrow from Cairo's moneylenders to fund his trip back across the desert, to Mali, and the moneylenders charged him compound interest; he ended up paying back 233 percent on each dinar borrowed.[5]

ABUBAKARI'S ADVENTURE to the west had brought Mansa Musa to the throne; and thanks to Mansa Musa's pilgrimage east, Mali appeared more and more often on European maps of the world. The Catalan Atlas, an ambitious world map produced for Peter of Aragon by the Jewish cartographer Cresques Abraham, shows Mansa Musa himself seated on a golden throne, holding a golden scepter and a golden orb, wearing a crown of gold.

In the remaining years of Mansa Musa's rule, European traders and embassies from European governments traversed the Sahara again and again, seeking gold, forging alliances; and after Musa's death in 1337, Mali remained strong. But outside the country, the exaggerated legends of Mali's wealth, of the riches that needed only to be plucked from the ground, continued to grow. And inside Mali, factions and political parties began to clot towards critical mass.

Mansa Musa's son Maghan, who had served as regent during his father's extended absence from the country, inherited his crown. But he died after a brief four-year reign, and the throne was claimed by his uncle Mansa Sulayman. "A most avaricious and worthless man," Ibn Battuta calls him; arriving in Mali halfway through Mansa Sulayman's reign, Ibn Battuta was